

# ELLIOT SPEARS

PhD Candidate in Economics  
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## RESEARCH FIELDS

**Primary:** Macro-Finance; Monetary Economics; Banking

**Additional:** Macroeconomics; Asset Pricing

## EDUCATION

|                                                      |                                      |                      |
|------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|----------------------|
| <b>University of Washington</b><br>Seattle, WA       | <i>PhD in Economics</i>              | <b>Expected 2027</b> |
| <b>University of Texas at Austin</b><br>Austin, TX   | <i>MA in Economics</i>               | <b>2022</b>          |
| <b>University of Colorado Boulder</b><br>Boulder, CO | <i>BA in Mathematics, Philosophy</i> | <b>2019</b>          |

## REFERENCES

**Professor Fabio Ghironi**  
Committee Chair; Department of Economics  
[ghiro@uw.edu](mailto:ghiro@uw.edu) | 206-543-5795  
**Professor Chang-Jin Kim**  
Department of Economics  
[changjin@uw.edu](mailto:changjin@uw.edu) | 206-543-5955

**Professor Philip Bond**  
Department Chair; Department of Finance and Business Economics  
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**Dr. Galip Kemal Ozhan**  
International Monetary Fund  
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## WORKING PAPERS

*Full abstracts appear on page 3*

|                                                                          |             |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| <b>Forward Guidance and the Dynamics of Bank Credit</b>                  | <b>2025</b> |
| <b>Government Debt and the Transmission of Monetary Policy to Credit</b> | <b>2025</b> |
| <b>Social Security and Unfunded Government Debt</b>                      | <b>2026</b> |

## CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

|                                                                      |                        |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| Southern Economic Association Annual Conference ( <i>scheduled</i> ) | Houston, November 2026 |
| Royal Economic Society Annual Conference                             | Newcastle, July 2026   |
| T2M Conference, PhD Student Session                                  | Montreal, June 2026    |

## TEACHING EXPERIENCE

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**Instructor of Record, University of Washington** **2022–Present**

Department of Economics, Seattle, WA

**Courses taught independently**

**ECON 200** Introduction to Microeconomics Undergraduate

**ECON 201** Introduction to Macroeconomics Undergraduate

**ECON 301** Intermediate Macroeconomics Undergraduate

Sole instructor for sections of up to 180 students, with twice-weekly lectures; independently developed course materials, assignments, and examinations.

**Mean student evaluation rating: 4.6/5.0 across 11 evaluated courses.**

**Graduate Teaching Assistant, University of Washington** **2022–Present**

University of Washington, Seattle, WA

**Courses supported as teaching assistant**

**OPMGT 502** Introduction to Operations Management MBA; Autumn 2025

*Taught under Professor Apurva Jain.*

**OPMGT 443** Inventory and Supply Chain Management Undergraduate

## HONORS AND AWARDS

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**Steven Langton Teaching Award** 2026

Awarded to graduate student instructors who demonstrate excellence in teaching.

**Graduate Student Conference Presentation Award** 2026

**Economics Department Travel Award** 2026

**George and Pearl Corkery Scholarship** 2022

Award created to support the recruitment of exceptional applicants to the PhD program.

## TECHNICAL SKILLS

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**Programming** Python, R, Stata, MATLAB, SQL,  $\LaTeX$

**Libraries** pandas, NumPy, scikit-learn, statsmodels, seaborn, matplotlib, tidyverse, fixest

**Econometric Methods** OLS, 2SLS, logit, difference-in-differences, VAR, ARIMA, local projections, Kalman filtering

**Modeling and Analysis** DSGE models, stochastic calculus, time-series econometrics, forecasting, machine learning, causal inference, partial differential equations

## LANGUAGES AND CERTIFICATION

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**Languages** English (native); German (fluent)

**Certification** Goethe-Zertifikat C1 (German), 2016

*Updated August 2026*

## RESEARCH ABSTRACTS

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### **Forward Guidance and the Dynamics of Bank Credit**

In this paper, I examine how bank credit responds to the central bank's forward guidance by using high-frequency monetary policy surprises extracted from asset-price movements around FOMC announcements. When the central bank surprises markets with a policy tightening, banks contract credit and de-lever, generating a sharp and persistent decline in lending. By contrast, expansionary forward guidance shocks lead to a delayed and substantially weaker response, revealing an asymmetry between tightening and easing episodes. I develop a quantitative model with a banking sector that makes sense of these asymmetric dynamics and use it to study the macroprudential implications of forward guidance. The model shows that, even at the zero lower bound, expansionary forward guidance raises output only modestly (on the order of a few basis points). This muted response reflects the key role of bank balance sheets in shaping the transmission of monetary policy: while forward guidance relaxes financial constraints by improving intermediary balance sheets, these adjustments are quantitatively limited. Taken together, the results suggest that forward guidance is most effective at restraining credit during tightening episodes, while its ability to stimulate activity at the zero lower bound is constrained.

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### **Government Debt and the Transmission of Monetary Policy to Credit**

This paper shows that government debt weakens the transmission of monetary policy to bank credit. Using a narrative approach to identify monetary policy shocks and using aggregated bank-level data, I find that contractionary policy has significantly smaller effects on lending and capital accumulation when debt-to-GDP is high. I explain this using a model with financial intermediaries in a fiscal theory framework with active fiscal and passive monetary policy. Higher debt raises expected inflation, which dampens the response of real interest rates to policy tightening and magnifies its effects on credit. The model matches the empirical evidence and implies that sufficiently high debt counteracts the effects of monetary policy on credit. The model also predicts that debt maturity structure is relevant to monetary policy's transmission; as maturity structure shortens, monetary policy becomes even less effective under high-debt states at contracting credit.

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### **Social Security and Unfunded Government Debt**

I study how population aging affects macroeconomic outcomes when rising Social Security obligations are financed under different fiscal-monetary regimes. I build a life-cycle model with workers and retirees, capital accumulation, pay-as-you-go transfers, government debt, and a fiscal-valuation channel through which unfunded government liabilities affect inflation and the real value of debt. Using current U.S. demographic projections, I simulate a medium-run retirement wave shock and compare funded versus unfunded financing of the subsequent transfer burden. The results show that financing assumptions significantly shape the adjustment: without reform to the pension program, unfunded accommodation produces the largest inflation response. Benefit cuts under a fully-funded regime reduce fiscal pressure, but redistribute welfare across retirees, workers, and especially future generations. Immediate and gradual cuts paired with capital-income-tax adjustments rank first and second in terms of overall welfare, respectively, and prove to be robust in this regard. No single benefit-reform package proves to be Pareto optimal: grandfathering protects current retirees by shifting losses toward near-term future generations, while unfunded reforms benefit current generations at future cohorts' expense.